

Dopamine FASTING

There can be too much of a good thing

WORDS ROSE GOODMAN & ALI HORSFALL

We've all heard of the saying 'everything in moderation' when it comes to weighing up how many glasses of wine we have in the evening, or whether to eat that second slice of cheesecake. But did you know that the same concept can apply to our 'feel-good' hormones? Cutting out those everyday things that bring us a flood of short-term joy - such as scrolling through Facebook or watching Netflix - can mean ramping up that pleasure response in the brain when you get them back. So, are you ready to try dopamine fasting?

The pleasure hormone

Dopamine is the mighty chemical messenger involved in motivation. It rises in response to rewards and encourages us to seek gratification. Because of this, dopamine is blamed for addictive behaviours, such as compulsive online shopping and emotional eating.

“ BY ABSTAINING IN THE SHORT-TERM, YOU’LL REBOOT THE BRAIN’S REWARD SYSTEM ”

MAKE IT WORK FOR YOU

Dopamine fasting doesn't mean cutting out everything, just those activities that you compulsively rely on for that flood of dopamine. It will be different for everyone. If it's social media, try no screen time. If you find yourself binge-watching box sets on Netflix instead of getting a good night's sleep, try bedtime yoga or meditation. And, if you can't resist sweet snacks, opt for sugar-free days. While some people have taken this wellness trend to the extreme, you don't need to 'fast' for long periods of time. Try one or two hours in the evening or one day at the weekend. Or simply switch off while on your staycation - whatever works for you.

It's backed by science

The wellness trend, popularised by Californian psychiatrist Dr Cameron Sepah, may balance negative behaviours linked to

dopamine surges. The thinking is this: by abstaining from sins, stimulants and small pleasures in the short-term, you'll reboot the brain's reward system to value them more when you indulge. It also means trying to find pleasure in more natural activities, such as going for a walk or meditating. And, perhaps being able to address, and take control of, compulsive behaviours that are having a negative impact on our happiness. ■

